

Week 10: The Assassination of Abraham Lincoln/Waging Peace

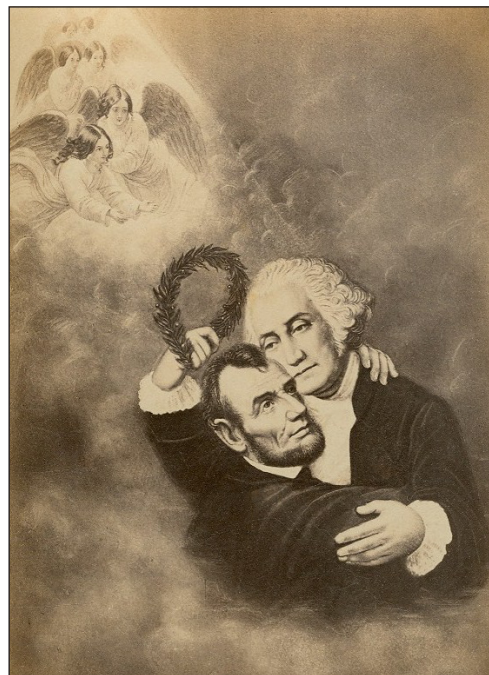
Questions

1. Do you think that Reconstruction was shaping up to be essentially conservative, or the “culmination” of the great social revolution of emancipation?
2. Was Radical Reconstruction doomed to failure? Consider all the “players” (President, Congress, the Republicans in the South, the ex-Confederates, and African-Americans) when formulating your answer.
3. An historian of this era writes that “The freedmen made an amazing transformation after the Civil War; slaves became political men acting forcefully to crush the most cherished illusions of their former masters. The tragedy of Reconstruction is that they received so much less than they gave.” What do you think is meant by this statement?
4. Fine. You think Reconstruction was an abysmal failure. What, then, is your plan? Discuss your aims, implementation and goals, always contrasting them with the original.
5. To what extent and why do you agree or disagree with historian James McPherson’s contention that the Civil War was “The Second American Revolution”?

Key Terms

- 13th Amendment
- 14th Amendment
- Wartime Reconstruction
- Proclamation of Amnesty and Reconstruction
- “When Johnny Comes Marching Home Again”
- Theory of Indissoluble Union
- Lincoln’s Second Inaugural Address

The Death of Lincoln



President Lincoln’s death was met with an outpouring of grief, at least in the North. Shortly after the assassination, Walt Whitman published his famous poem “O Captain! My Captain!” in the President’s honor. Printmakers rushed to meet demand for images of the slain leader, including “The Assassination of Abraham Lincoln” (above) and “The Apotheosis” (below), which imagines George Washington welcoming his successor into heaven.

“O Captain! My Captain!”

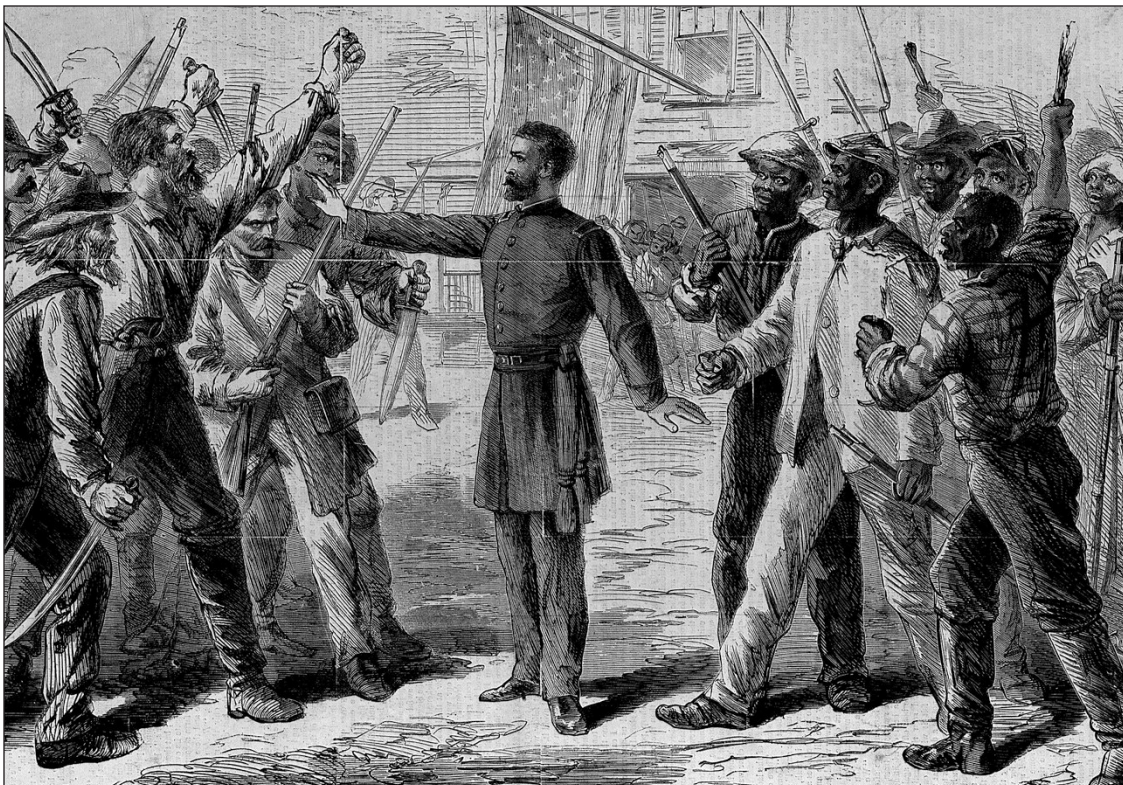
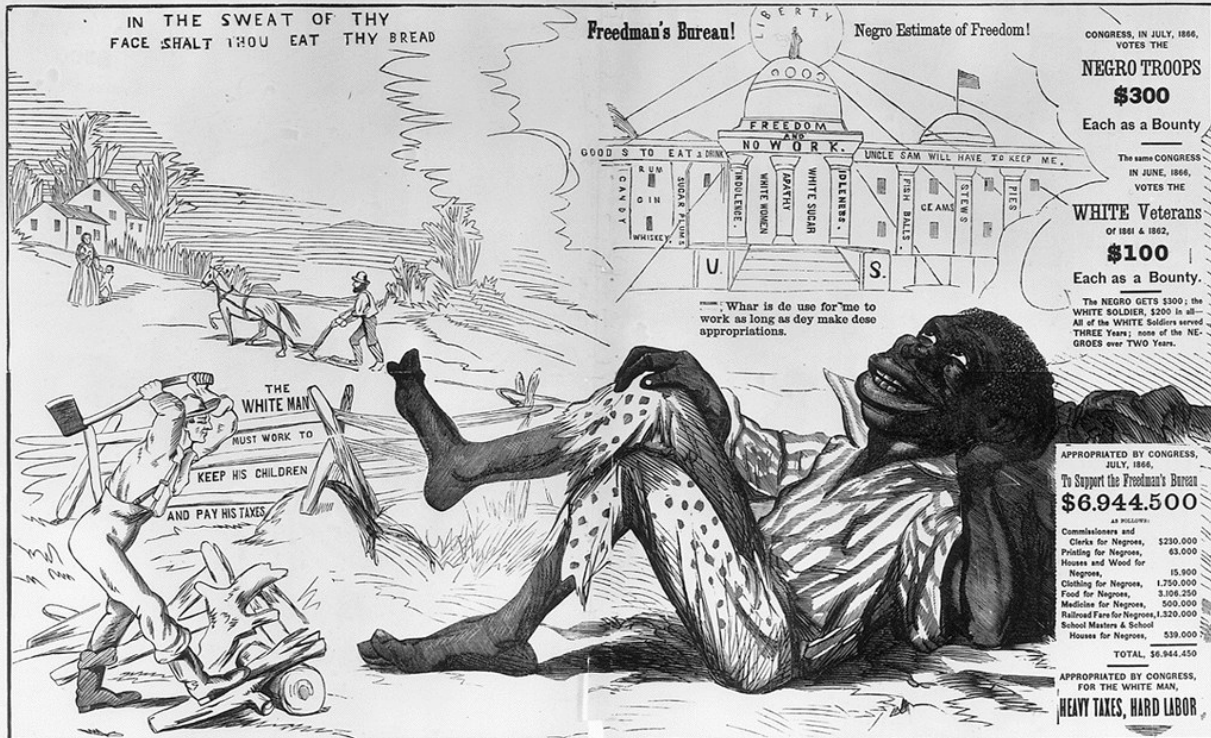
O Captain! my Captain! our fearful trip is done,
The ship has weathered every rack, the prize we sought
is won,
The port is near; the bells I hear; the people all exulting,
While follow eyes the steady keel, the vessel grim and
daring;
But O heart! heart! heart! O the bleeding drops of red,
Where on the deck my Captain lies, Fallen cold and
dead.

O Captain! my Captain! rise up and hear the bells;
Rise up—for you the flag is flung—for you the bugle trills,
For you bouquets and ribboned wreaths—for you the
shores a-crowding,
For you they call, the swaying mass, their eager faces
turning;
Here Captain! dear father! This arm beneath your head!
It is some dream that on the deck. You’ve fallen cold and
dead.

My captain does not answer; his lips are pale and still,
My father does not feel my arm, he has no pulse nor will,
The ship is anchored safe and sound, its voyage closed
and done,
From fearful trip the victor ship comes in with object
won;
Exult, O shores, and ring O bells! But I, with mournful
tread,
Walk the deck my Captain lies, Fallen cold and dead.

THE FREEDMAN'S BUREAU!

AN AGENCY TO KEEP THE **NEGRO** IN IDLENESS AT THE **EXPENSE** OF THE WHITE MAN.
 TWICE VETOED BY THE **PRESIDENT**, AND MADE A LAW BY **CONGRESS**.
SUPPORT CONGRESS & YOU SUPPORT THE NEGRO. SUSTAIN THE PRESIDENT & YOU PROTECT THE WHITE MAN



During the tumultuous era of Reconstruction, the agency with primary responsibility for overseeing the federal government's efforts in the South was the Bureau of Refugees, Freedmen, and Abandoned Lands—more commonly referred to as the Freedmen's Bureau. The Bureau was highly controversial: Republicans in the North portrayed the agency in heroic terms, helping to keep the peace in the South (bottom) while Southerners argued that the Bureau allowed former slaves to avoid labor at the expense of hardworking Southern whites (top). Though the former interpretation was closer to the truth, the latter achieved wider acceptance, even in the North.